

Ubuntu Unity desktop

Canonical has another idea for the Gnome shell that they will use in Ubuntu 11.04 onwards. It is based on Ubuntu Netbook remix

Gnome apps revamped

Gnome 3 comes with revamped applications: Nautilus, Empathy, Evolution, all have received many updates.

A look at Gnome 3

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So it's been nearly a decade since Gnome 2, and the desktop has done quite well for itself in the meantime. Thanks to being the default choice in popular distros such as Ubuntu and Linux Mint, it is perhaps now more widely known among new Linux users than KDE.

The latest release of Gnome takes a bold plunge into a completely new kind of desktop, breaking a lot of desktop conventions we are used to. There is no task-bar on screen, no maximise or minimise buttons, and no desktop to speak of. It will challenge your way of using a computer and you will either love it immediately, or love it after you've used it for a while. Unless, of course, you give up. But you won't will you?

Message tray

Here lie all the system tray icons you are used to. This panel is normally hidden, but is activated when the user approaches the bottom-right corner of the screen. The icons expand when clicked, to reveal the name of the application they are associated with. You can click (right / left) the icons to reveal their usual functions.

At the bottom centre of the screen, all your messages will appear. They do not need to be interacted with, they merely pop up for a short while and go away. If a notification is of importance to you, you can click it to launch the associated action. Simple notifications will just come and go, but messages requiring a response will be queued.

One can even reply to IMs straight from your notification.

Window Switcher

The good old [Alt] + [Tab] functionality has been revamped with Gnome 3. Windows are grouped by Application, such that you will only see application

icons while alt-tabbing, however on selecting an application window with multiple windows they are previewed below the application icon, such that you can select them based on content rather than their icon. Additionally, all applications from all workspaces are shown here, with icons small light separator between applications on different workspaces.

Here you can interact with the window switcher using your mouse or keyboard. Keyboard controls isn't as straightforward as it used to be. You will either need to select an application window using the mouse, or use the arrow keys in addition to alt-tabbing to move the window you wish to switch to.

Window controls

The maximise and minimise buttons are gone! Hold off your lament, it is still possible to maximise or minimise windows, it is just that the buttons are gone. Gnome 3 supports the methods Windows 7 uses for managing windows (move to the right to maximise to the right, move to top to maximise, etc), and you can always double click to maximise.

Minimising is another matter, you can right-click on the title bar and click on minimize. It might seem too inconvenient, but trust us, the new mechanism of managing windows is such that minimising windows becomes an obsolete feature.

Only the close button is shown on windows, and that too is absent on windows that already have a close button on them.

Activities view

The activities view shows an overview of your open windows, your workspaces, and favourite applications. It also lets you switch between two modes, Windows, and Applications.

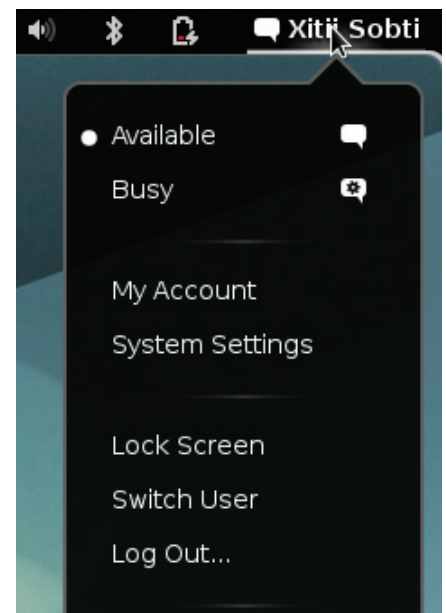
In the Windows view, you can see an overview of your open windows; you can click on a window to activate it. You can also move windows from the overview in the centre, and arrange them into your visual list

of workspaces on the right. On the left-hand side is a dock that lists your running, and favourite applications. This works similar to the Windows 7 taskbar. You can mark applications as favourite and they will always appear here even when not running.

In the Applications view, you can see a list of all your installed applications, with categories on the right. There is no sub-categorisation of applications.

Activities view button

This button is to switch to your activities overview. The activities view is where you can see the running applications and launch new ones. You do not even need to click the button, as the top-left area of the screen is a hot-spot and will trigger the activities view if you move the mouse to that corner.



User menu

This button will reveal activities related to the current user account. From here one may access their preferences, set their social networking status, and log off / shut down etc.